Training for a first marathon

Most beginners need 16 to 20 weeks to prepare for 26.2 miles. If you can already run three miles comfortably, you have a good starting point.

Build your weekly mileage slowly, by no more than about ten percent a week. Run three or four days a week, and make one of them the long run on the weekend. Add a mile to the long run most weeks and cut back every fourth week so your legs can recover. Do most runs at an easy pace where you can still talk.

In the last two to three weeks, taper: keep the pace but reduce the mileage so you arrive at the start line fresh. Practise your race-day breakfast and your energy gels on long runs, and try not to wear anything new on race morning.

On the day, start slower than feels necessary. Many first-timers run the first half too fast and struggle through the last six miles.